Q+A

# Shuttle Star

**Ashwini Ponnappa** was the only Indian to compete in the inaugural edition of BDMNTN-XL, a new international badminton tourney with a new format, held in Indonesia

**Q. Why did you decide to sign up for the BDMNTN-XL league?**
Firstly, because it was held in Jakarta, a place where the badminton stadiums are full and the fans are amazing. Also, the league's unique format and women's doubles as an event, and most importantly, the opportunity to play with some of the world's best players.

**Q. What were the challenges of playing in the 3v3 format, with a 10-minute clock running down at the end each quarter?**
Previously, we only played 3v3 during practice sessions for fun. The 10-minute timer added a different layer of difficulty and you had to strategise well, since we were not working towards a visible number that marked the end of a set. The style of play was fast and a lot around the initial few points. Whoever got a good start had an advantage.

**Q. What do you think this tournament will do for the popularity of the sport?**
It was exciting, especially since so many of the best players from different countries played on the same team. It was interesting for badminton fans to see Olympic medallists relax and have fun on court, especially in the 3v3 matches. While everyone was competitive, the fact that the teams were so diverse made it fun to watch.

**Q. What have you been working on during your break since the Paris Olympics? How has this time helped you regroup for the tournaments ahead?**
I'll be playing the Syed Modi International and a couple of more tournaments in the time ahead. After the Paris 2024 Games, I had taken time off from the sport to rest and recover, both mentally and physically.

–with Shail Desai

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